



The Vulcan Papers

Twelve papers for delivery in open lodge — masonic lore, ritual and responsibilities. Eight of ten minutes, four of twenty.



Every paper is drawn from openly published masonic literature. Nothing here discloses the esoteric work of any degree; all of it is safe to deliver with visitors present, provided the visitors are brethren.

Vulcan Lodge No. 4510 · Roman Road, Linthorpe, Middlesbrough



The Brother Outside the Door

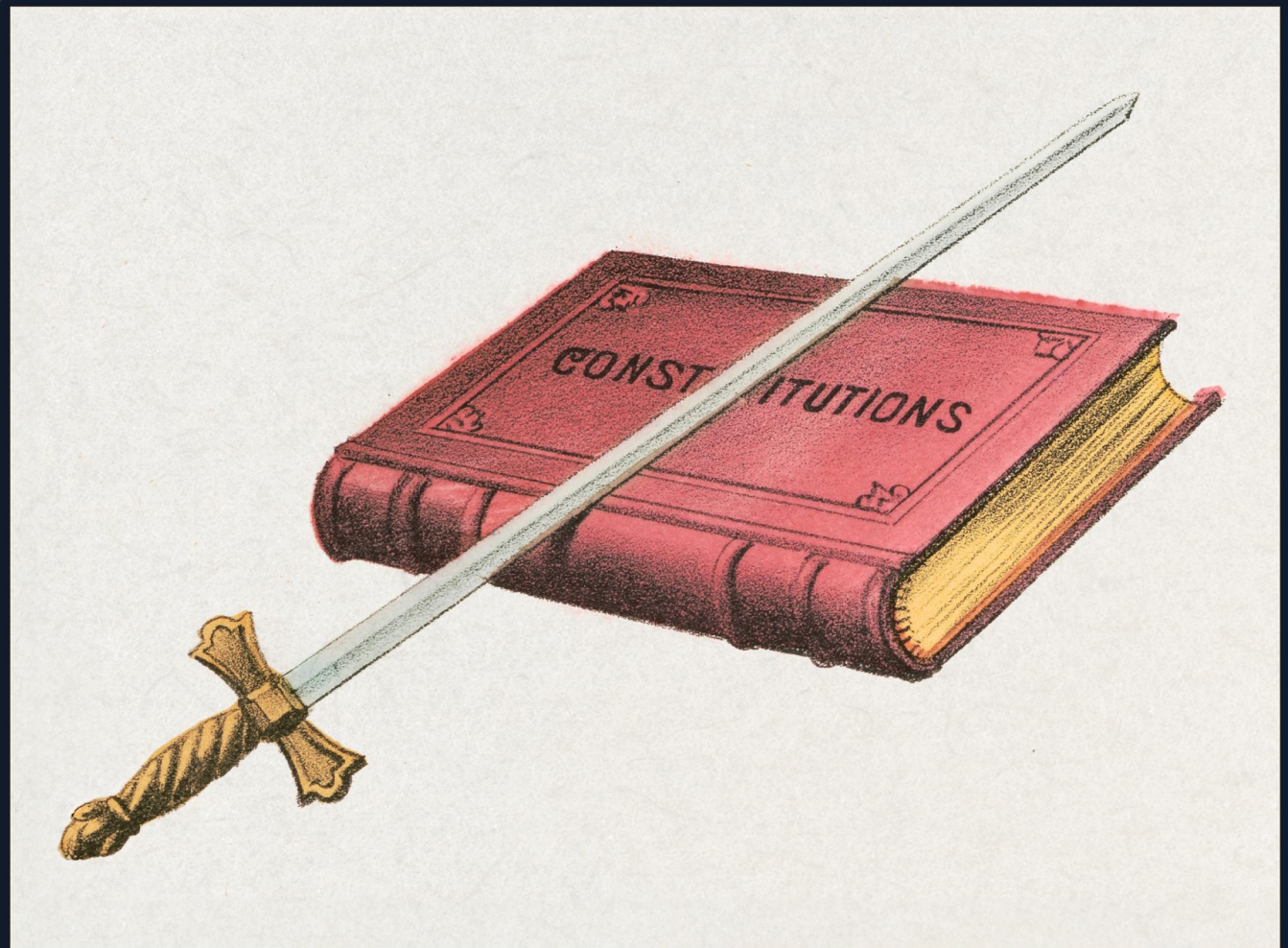
The Tyler

RESPONSIBILITIES

The oldest office in the lodge and the only one historically paid. Why he sits outside, what he is actually guarding against, and why the last toast of the night belongs to him.

ON THE TABLE

The Tyler's sword, and his chair outside the door



Book of Constitutions Guarded by the Tyler's Sword — Unknown authorUnknown author
Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

HOW THE PAPER RUNS

0:00	Opening
1:00	The word
2:30	The oldest office, and the paid one
4:00	What he is actually guarding against
6:00	The sword
7:30	His other duty
8:45	Closing: the last toast

THREE THINGS TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 To *tyle* is to roof — to make a place covered, so what happens inside is not visible outside.



THE BROTHER OUTSIDE THE DOOR

- 2 A cowan is not a stranger. He is a man who does something that looks like the work without having earned it.
- 3 The Tyler sees none of the ceremony, and is given the last toast of the night — for the brethren who are not there.

IF YOU ARE ASKED

Is the Tyler always a member of the lodge?

Not necessarily, and historically often not. Many towns had a Tyler who served several lodges for a fee.

Why a sword and not something else?

Practical origin — an armed man on a stair. It survives as the emblem of the office.

What exactly is a cowan?

A Scots operative term for an untrained man who built without mortar. It means a pretender to the craft, not merely a stranger.

Is the Tyler still paid?

In some lodges, yes — a small honorarium is still common and entirely traditional.

SOURCES

- Emulation Ritual, published by Lewis Masonic — the opening and the duties of the office
- Anderson, The Constitutions of the Free-Masons, 1723
- Knoop & Jones, The Genesis of Freemasonry (1947) — on cowans and operative practice
- Harry Carr, The Freemason at Work — the standard answer book on questions of this kind
- Your own lodge's nineteenth-century accounts, for the Tyler's fee

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Rough and Smooth

The two ashlar

SYMBOLISM

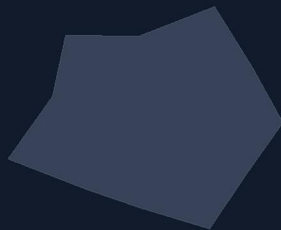
The simplest symbol in the lodge, and the one most worth ten unhurried minutes. Operative origin, speculative meaning, and why the perfect ashlar hangs rather than sits.

ON THE TABLE

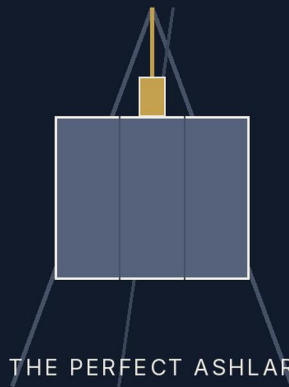
The lodge's own rough and perfect ashlar, on the table

ROUGH AND SMOOTH

One stone waiting. One stone under tension, held by iron, on its way into a wall it will not leave.



THE ROUGH ASHLAR
as it came from the quarry



THE PERFECT ASHLAR
squared, tried, and being lifted into place

The work was subtraction. Everything removed is gone, and the point of it is not the stone — a perfect ashlar on its own is useless. It is only anything at all when it is in a course.

Diagram drawn for *The Vulcan Papers*.

HOW THE PAPER RUNS

0:00	Opening
1:30	Start with the trade
3:00	What the working actually involved
5:00	Why one of them hangs
7:00	The part we usually get wrong
9:00	Closing

THREE THINGS TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 Ashlar is a builder's word, not a masonic one: squared, dressed stone laid in courses.
- 2 The perfect ashlar hangs from a lewis because it is shown in the act of being lifted into the wall.
- 3 The work was subtraction. Everything removed is gone, and the point of it is not the stone.

IF YOU ARE ASKED

Are the ashlar's movable or immovable jewels?

In the English working they are immovable jewels, with the tracing board. Other constitutions class them differently — a common source of confusion when visiting.

Why is the perfect ashlar suspended?

It hangs from a lewis, showing the dressed stone at the moment of being lifted into the building.

ROUGH AND SMOOTH



Does the rough ashlar mean a bad man?

No. It means an unworked one. The stone itself is sound; nothing has been done to it yet.

What is "trying and proving"?

Testing the worked faces with square and straightedge before the stone is accepted.

SOURCES

- Emulation Ritual — the explanation of the First Degree tracing board
- Harry Carr, The Freemason at Work, on the jewels and their classification
- Knoop & Jones, The Mediaeval Mason — operative practice, ashlar and rubble
- Any stone-built street in Middlesbrough, for the difference between a front elevation and a side wall

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Up and Down

The Wardens' columns

RITUAL

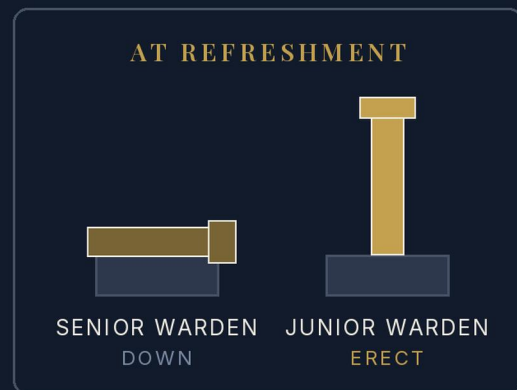
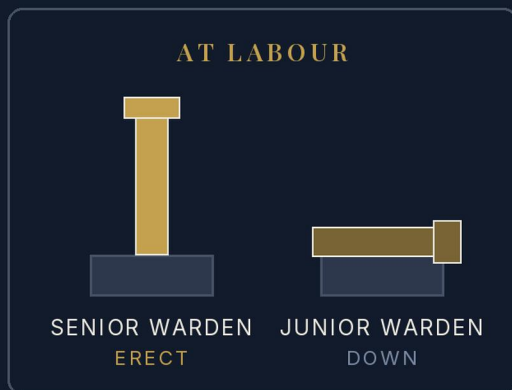
A small mechanical detail almost nobody watches, which turns out to carry the entire logic of opening, calling off, calling on and closing.

ON THE TABLE

The Senior and Junior Wardens' columns

THE WARDENS' COLUMNS

The only visible indication of what state the lodge is in. One glance at either pedestal tells a brother who has charge of him.



When the lodge is closed, both are down.

Calling off is not closing — the lodge is suspended, and passes from the Senior Warden's charge to the Junior Warden's in a single movement that takes about a second.

Diagram drawn for *The Vulcan Papers*.

HOW THE PAPER RUNS

0:00	Opening
1:00	What they are
2:30	Why those two
4:30	Calling off
6:00	The orders
7:30	Why this survives
9:00	Closing

THREE THINGS TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 Senior Warden's column erect at labour; Junior Warden's at refreshment; both down when closed.
- 2 Called off is not closed. The lodge is suspended, not ended, and can be called on without a fresh opening.
- 3 The columns are a signal designed for the brother who missed the words — a visitor, or a man back from the door.

IF YOU ARE ASKED

Which column is up during labour?

The Senior Warden's. The Junior Warden's is down.

And at refreshment?

They reverse. Both are down when the lodge is closed.

UP AND DOWN



Is calling off the same as closing?

No. Called off means suspended — the lodge still exists and can be called on again without a fresh opening.

Do all constitutions do it this way?

No. Practice varies, and the columns are a frequent point of difference when visiting. Watch rather than assume.

SOURCES

- Emulation Ritual — opening, closing, calling off and calling on
- Harry Carr, *The Freemason at Work* — on the Wardens' columns and variations between workings
- Colin Dyer, *Symbolism in Craft Freemasonry* — on the orders of architecture

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Free, and Accepted

Two words on every summons

LORE

Two words nobody reads, both doing real historical work: the freedom of an operative craft, and the accepted gentlemen who took the lodges over and never gave them back.

ON THE TABLE

Your own summons



Elias Ashmole by John Riley — After John Riley
Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

HOW THE PAPER RUNS

0:00	Opening
1:15	Free: three candidates
4:00	Accepted: the more interesting word
6:30	What the "and" is doing
8:15	Why keep saying it
9:30	Closing

THREE THINGS TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 Free carried three meanings: the freestone, the freedom of the guild, and a free man.
- 2 Accepted means the non-operatives admitted from the 1600s — Moray 1641, Ashmole 1646.
- 3 Every man in this room is an accepted mason. Not one of us is free of the craft in the trade sense.

IF YOU ARE ASKED

FREE, AND ACCEPTED



So which meaning of "free" is the right one?

Probably all three, at different periods. The single-answer approach is a Victorian tidy-up.

Who was the first accepted mason?

Unanswerable. The earliest well-documented English admission is Elias Ashmole at Warrington in 1646; Robert Moray at Newcastle in 1641 is earlier and Scottish.

Did operatives and accepted men meet together?

Yes, for a long period. That overlap is exactly how the transition happened.

Why do the Antients' descendants say "Antient Free and Accepted"?

A claim to the older usage, made during the eighteenth-century schism. See Paper Eleven.

SOURCES

- Anderson, The Constitutions of the Free-Masons, 1723
- Elias Ashmole's diary, 16 October 1646 — the Warrington admission
- Knoop & Jones, The Genesis of Freemasonry — the operative-to-speculative transition
- David Stevenson, The Origins of Freemasonry: Scotland's Century 1590–1710 — for Moray and the Scottish evidence

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The Hardest Job in the Lodge

The Almoner RESPONSIBILITIES

The office least fought over and most needed. What the Almoner actually does, where the money comes from, and why the job gets harder as a lodge ages.

ON THE TABLE

The Almoner's jewel — a scrip purse

THE ALMONER'S JEWEL

A scrip purse — a pilgrim's satchel, for what you carry on the road — charged with a heart. Money and feeling together.



The office least fought over and most needed.
SCRIP PURSE, CHARGED WITH A HEART
The Almoner looks inward — our brethren, their widows and dependants.
The Charity Steward looks outward — what this lodge gives away.

Diagram drawn for The Vulcan Papers.

HOW THE PAPER RUNS

0:00	Opening
1:00	The jewel
2:15	What the Almoner actually does
4:30	The difference nobody can state
6:00	Where the help actually comes from
7:45	Why it gets harder
9:00	Closing

THREE THINGS TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 The jewel is a scrip purse — a pilgrim's satchel — charged with a heart.
- 2 Almoner looks inward to our own; Charity Steward looks outward to what we give.
- 3 The Masonic Charitable Foundation (2016) covers far more than poverty, and the Almoner can start the application.

IF YOU ARE ASKED

THE HARDEST JOB IN THE LODGE



Almoner or Charity Steward?

Almoner looks inward — our brethren, widows and dependants. Charity Steward looks outward — what we give. Sometimes combined in a small lodge.

Must a brother be destitute to get help?

No. The Masonic Charitable Foundation supports a far wider range of need than relief of poverty.

Can the Almoner start an application?

Yes, and very often he must, because the brethren who need it most will not ask.

When was the MCF formed?

2016, amalgamating four long-standing masonic charities.

What's on the jewel?

A scrip purse — a pilgrim's satchel — charged with a heart.

SOURCES

- Masonic Charitable Foundation — published guidance on what support is available and how to apply
- UGLE Book of Constitutions — the office and its duties
- Your Provincial Almoner, who will brief any lodge Almoner who asks

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The Lewis

A cramp, and a son

SYMBOLISM

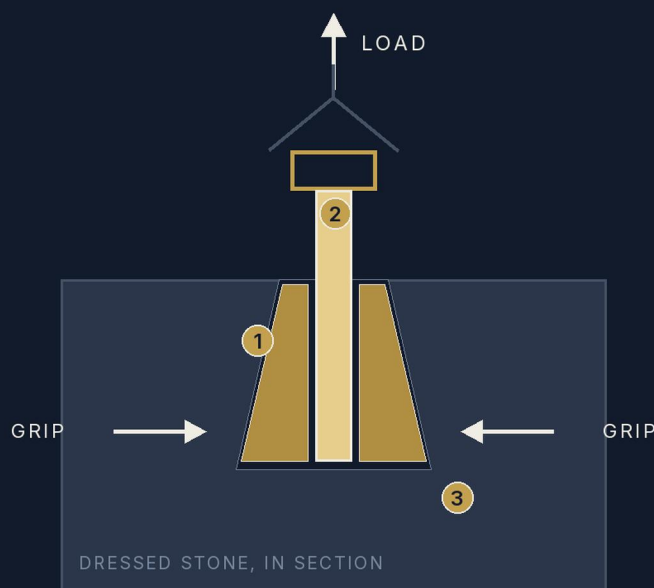
An iron device for lifting dressed stone, and the word we give to a mason's son. One object, one pun, and one genuine obligation.

ON THE TABLE

A lewis, if the lodge has one; the Junior Warden's pedestal if not

THE LEWIS

Three pieces of iron in a dovetailed hole. The outer wedges splay into the undercut; the centre key drops between them and forces them apart. The heavier the stone, the tighter the grip.



- 1 outer wedge
- 2 centre key, dropped in last
- 3 dovetail, wider at the bottom

Lift, and the key drives the wedges outward into the undercut — the load itself is what makes it hold. There is no catch to fail and no knot to slip.

Set the stone down and the tension comes off. The key lifts out, the wedges fall slack, and the lewis is free — leaving a small dovetailed hole that the next course covers for ever.

Diagram drawn for The Vulcan Papers.

HOW THE PAPER RUNS

0:00	Opening
1:00	The iron
3:30	Where you will see it in this room
5:00	The son
6:30	The privilege, and what is left of it
8:00	Why this is the best symbol we own
9:30	Closing

THREE THINGS TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 Three pieces of iron in a dovetailed hole. The heavier the stone, the tighter the grip.
- 2 A lewis is also a mason's son, charged to bear the burden his parents should be exempt from.
- 3 Under UGLE a lewis gets no precedence and no early admission. He gets a name and an expectation.



IF YOU ARE ASKED

How does a lewis work?

Three pieces of iron in a dovetailed hole. The outer wedges splay into the undercut; the centre piece locks them. The load tightens the grip.

Can a lewis be initiated younger?

Not under UGLE. Twenty-one, or eighteen by dispensation, the same as anyone. Other constitutions vary.

Does a lewis get initiated first?

Historically a recognised privilege; not a right under UGLE today.

Where is it in the lodge?

Holding the perfect ashlar on its tripod, and named on the First Degree tracing board.

SOURCES

- Emulation Ritual — the First Degree tracing board explanation
- Harry Carr, The Freemason at Work — on the lewis, its privileges and the variations between constitutions
- UGLE Book of Constitutions — age of candidates
- Knoop & Jones, The Mediaeval Mason — lifting tackle and operative practice

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Neither Religion nor Politics

A rule with a reason

LORE

Not squeamishness, and not neutrality for its own sake. A deliberate design decision taken in a country that had just spent a century killing itself over both.

ON THE TABLE

Anderson's Constitutions, 1723 — the text of Charge I



THE CONSTITUTIONS OF THE FREE-MASONS.

CONTAINING THE
History, Charges, Regulations, &c.
of that most Ancient and Right
Worshipful *FRATERNITY*.

For the Use of the *LODGES*.



L O N D O N:

Printed by WILLIAM HUNTER, for JOHN SENEX at the *Globe*,
and JOHN HOOKE at the *Flower-de-luce* over-against *St. Dunstan's*
Church, in *Fleet-street*.

In the Year of Maſonry — 5723
Anno Domini — 1723

268. a 31.

Anderson's Constitutions — Christophe Dioux
Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

HOW THE PAPER RUNS

0:00	Opening
1:15	What the rule actually says
2:45	Now put a date on it
5:00	The genuinely radical part
6:45	What it cost, and what it bought
8:15	Saying it better
9:15	Closing

THREE THINGS TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 Anderson's Constitutions, 1723, Charge VI.2 — resolved against all politics.
- 2 Written by men whose fathers had seen civil war, a king beheaded, penal laws and the '15.
- 3 It is not an absence of conviction. It is an agreement about what we will not use against each other.

IF YOU ARE ASKED

NEITHER RELIGION NOR POLITICS



Where is this written?

Anderson's Constitutions, 1723, Charge I (God and Religion) and Charge VI.2 (Behaviour in the Lodge).

Does it mean masons have no beliefs?

The opposite. A belief in a Supreme Being is required. What is excluded is argument about whose.

Why does it make people suspicious?

Because a body that will not state a position invites others to invent one for it. That has been the cost from the beginning.

Has it ever been relaxed?

No. It remains in the Book of Constitutions and in every lodge's practice.

SOURCES

- James Anderson, The Constitutions of the Free-Masons, London, 1723 — full text widely available in facsimile
- UGLE Book of Constitutions, current edition
- Margaret Jacob, Living the Enlightenment — on masonry and eighteenth-century sociability
- John Hamill, The Craft: A History of English Freemasonry

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The Man You Bring In

Proposing a candidate

RESPONSIBILITIES

What you are actually signing when you put a man's name forward, what the ballot is for, and what the first twelve months should look like if you do it properly.

ON THE TABLE

A proposal form



Masonic Ballot Box 1740s — Catlemur
CC BY-SA 4.0 — commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Masonic_Ballot_Box_1740s.jpg

HOW THE PAPER RUNS

0:00	Opening
1:00	What the form actually is
2:30	The three ancient tests
4:15	The ballot, and what it is for
5:45	What you have actually signed up to
7:45	The number that should worry us
8:45	Closing

THREE THINGS TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 You are not filling an application. You and your seconder are vouching for a man to this lodge.



THE MAN YOU BRING IN

- 2 The ballot is secret and absolute, and no brother need give a reason.
- 3 The ceremony is not where we lose men. We lose them in the eleven months afterwards, when nobody rings.

IF YOU ARE ASKED

Must the proposer know the candidate personally?

Yes, and so should the seconder. Two men vouching, not one man and a signature.

Can a candidate be refused without a reason?

Yes. The ballot is secret and absolute, and no member need justify his vote.

What is the minimum age?

Twenty-one under UGLE, or eighteen by dispensation.

Whose job is the first year?

Formally the Mentor's. In practice the proposer's, and the lodge's.

SOURCES

- UGLE Book of Constitutions — qualifications of candidates, proposal and ballot
- UGLE Mentoring Scheme — published guidance for lodge Mentors and proposers
- Your Provincial Membership Officer, on retention figures for this Province

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The Picture We Stopped Looking At

The tracing boards

SYMBOLISM

Boards began as chalk drawn on the floor and mopped out at the close. What replaced the mop, what Josiah Bowring and John Harris put on the boards, and how much instruction is sitting in a picture that leans against the wall all evening.

ON THE TABLE

The lodge's own First Degree tracing board



Josiah Bowring (1757-1832) - First Degree Tracing Board - D2010-3 - Museum of Freemasonry — Josiah Bowring
Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

HOW THE PAPER RUNS

0:00	Opening
1:30	Part One: the mop and pail
4:00	Part Two: from floor to frame
6:30	Part Three: two men who painted them
10:00	Part Four: reading the First Degree board
15:00	Part Five: why a picture, and why it still works
17:30	Closing



THREE THINGS TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 Boards replaced designs drawn in chalk on the floor and mopped off at the close.
- 2 John Harris redesigned them; Emulation adopted his set in the 1840s and they became standard.
- 3 Harris went blind, and was kept until his death in 1873 by what is now the Masonic Charitable Foundation.

IF YOU ARE ASKED

Why "tracing" board?

Operative term — the board on which the master traced the working drawings the craftsmen built from.

What came before boards?

The design drawn in chalk and charcoal on the floor, and washed off at the close, often by the youngest Entered Apprentice.

Who designed ours?

Almost certainly after John Harris (1791–1873), adopted by Emulation in the 1840s and standard in England since.

Bowring or Harris?

Bowring's designs came first, c.1819, and survive in older lodges. Harris's became the standard.

Are the boards jewels?

In the English working the tracing board is an immovable jewel, with the two ashlar.

What's a trestle board?

The same object in American usage — though the term now more often means a lodge's newsletter.

SOURCES

- Emulation Ritual — the explanations of the three tracing boards
- T. O. Haunch, Tracing Boards: Their Development and Their Designers (Ars Quatuor Coronatorum, vol. 75) — the standard study
- Harry Carr, The Freemason at Work
- Museum of Freemasonry, London — holds Harris and Bowring originals
- Your own board: look for a maker's mark, a date, and a donor's inscription on the reverse

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Where Did Hiram Come From?

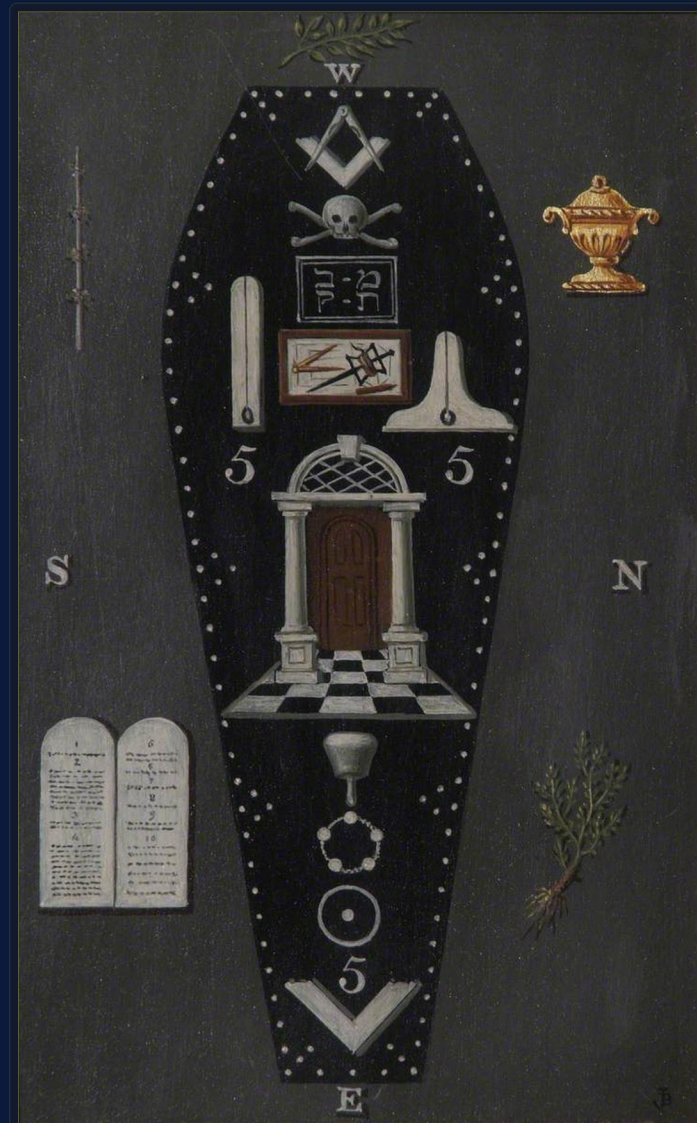
The making of a legend

LORE

The central legend of the Craft is absent from the earliest records and arrives in the 1720s and 30s. What the documents actually show, where the raw material came from, and why a fraternity of builders needed a story about a dead architect.

ON THE TABLE

The Third Degree tracing board



Josiah Bowring (1757-1832) - Third Degree Tracing Board - D2009-41iii - Museum of Freemasonry — Josiah Bowring
Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

HOW THE PAPER RUNS

- | | |
|-------|---|
| 0:00 | Opening |
| 2:00 | Part One: what the old documents actually say |
| 5:30 | Part Two: the man in the Bible |
| 8:00 | Part Three: the moment it appears |
| 11:00 | Part Four: the strangest document of all |
| 14:00 | Part Five: so where did it come from? |
| 16:30 | Part Six: why they needed it |

WHERE DID HIRAM COME FROM?



19:00 Closing

THREE THINGS TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 The legend is in none of the hundred-odd Old Charges, and the murder is not in scripture.
- 2 It appears in print in Prichard's hostile exposure, *Masonry Dissected*, 1730.
- 3 The Graham Manuscript of 1726 — found in 1936 — tells the same shape of story about Noah's grave.

IF YOU ARE ASKED

Is the murder in the Bible?

No. 1 Kings 7 and 2 Chronicles 2 introduce the craftsman and say nothing of his death.

What does "Abif" mean?

An honorific, roughly "his father" — a title of respect for a master craftsman.

When does the legend first appear in print?

Prichard's *Masonry Dissected*, 1730 — a hostile exposure, and a bestseller.

What is the Graham Manuscript?

A masonic document dated 1726, discovered 1936, containing a structurally similar story about the sons of Noah at their father's grave.

Did we always have three degrees?

No. English masonry worked two for most of its early life; the third takes shape in the 1720s.

So is it ancient or invented?

Unresolved, and honest scholarship says so. The evidence supports composition in the 1720s from older materials.

SOURCES

- The Regius Manuscript (c.1390) and Cooke Manuscript (c.1410) — the oldest Old Charges, both published in facsimile
- James Anderson, *The Constitutions of the Free-Masons*, 1723
- Samuel Prichard, *Masonry Dissected*, 1730
- The Graham Manuscript, 1726 — text and commentary in *Ars Quatuor Coronatorum*
- Knoop, Jones & Hamer, *The Early Masonic Catechisms* — the essential collection
- Harry Carr, *The Freemason at Work*
- Douglas Knoop & G. P. Jones, *The Genesis of Freemasonry*

This paper is about the documentary history of the legend — when it appears, in what sources, and what scholars make of it. It is drawn entirely from published masonic scholarship and stays well clear of the work itself.

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The Sixty Years' Quarrel

Antients, Moderns, and the Union of 1813

LORE

Two rival Grand Lodges, sixty years of mutual non-recognition, and the settlement that made our ritual what it is. Explains more about why we do what we do than any other single subject.

ON THE TABLE

The Lodge warrant, and its number



HRH the Duke of Sussex, Grand Master of the Moderns and first Grand Master of the United Grand Lodge, by Thomas Phillips — Thomas Phillips
Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons.

HOW THE PAPER RUNS

0:00	Opening
1:30	Part One: 1717, and a word of caution
4:00	Part Two: 1751, and the insult of a lifetime
7:00	Part Three: Laurence Dermott
9:30	Part Four: what they actually argued about
13:00	Part Five: sixty years, and two brothers
15:30	Part Six: the settlement
18:30	Closing

THREE THINGS TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 The Antients named their rivals the Moderns, and the insult has stuck for 270 years.
- 2 Deacons and the Royal Arch are Antient inheritances; the administrative shape is largely Moderns.
- 3 The union of 1813 was settled by two royal brothers, and lodge numbers were interleaved by drawing lots.



IF YOU ARE ASKED

Who were the Antients?

A rival Grand Lodge formed in 1751, largely by Irish masons in London, claiming to preserve older practice.

Why are the older body called Moderns?

Because the Antients named them that, as an insult, and it stuck for 270 years.

What did they disagree about?

Transposed words in the first two degrees, deacons, the Royal Arch, the Installed Master ceremony, saints' days, Christian references.

Who was Laurence Dermott?

Antients' Grand Secretary from 1752; author of Ahiman Rezon, 1756. The most effective polemicist we ever produced.

When and how did it end?

27 December 1813. The two Grand Masters were brothers — Sussex (Moderns) and Kent (Antients) — and Kent stood down.

Why is our number what it is?

The 1813 union interleaved both registers by drawing lots, with further renumberings in 1832 and 1863.

Is 1717 reliable?

Treat it with care. Our source is Anderson writing in 1738; modern scholarship questions the tidy version.

SOURCES

- Articles of Union, 1813 — printed in the Book of Constitutions
- Laurence Dermott, Ahiman Rezon, 1756
- James Anderson, The Constitutions of the Free-Masons, 1723 and 1738
- John Hamill, The Craft: A History of English Freemasonry
- Ric Berman, The Foundations of Modern Freemasonry — on the 1717 question
- Andrew Prescott, papers on the origins of Grand Lodge
- Ars Quatuor Coronatorum — the Lodge of Reconciliation and the 1813 settlement

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The Vulcan Papers · Vulcan Lodge No. 4510 · Roman Road, Linthorpe, Middlesbrough



The Charge, Line by Line

What we actually tell a new brother

RITUAL

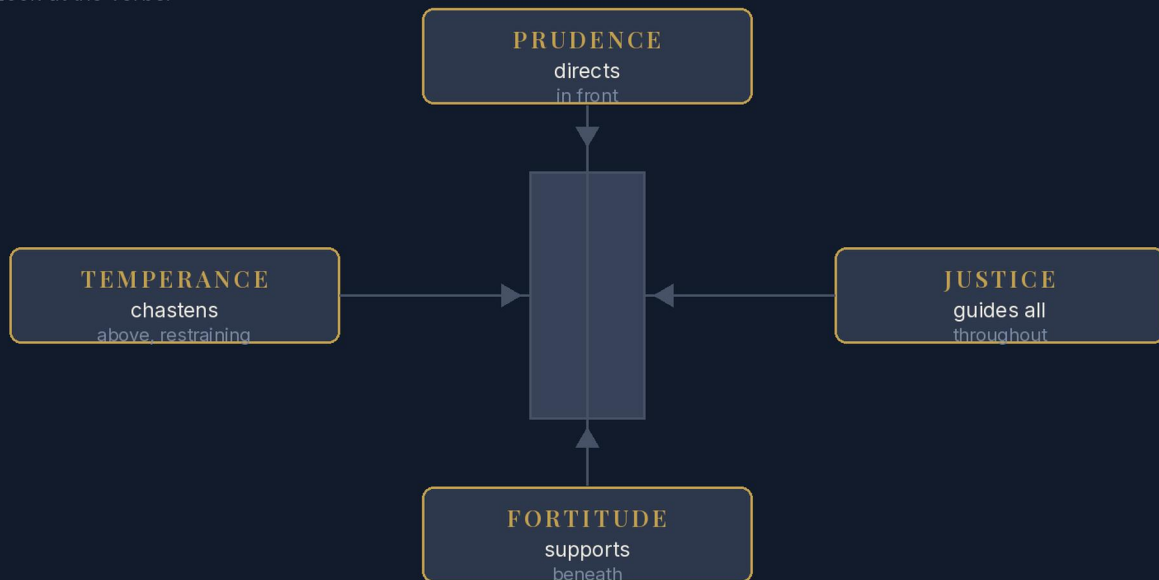
Everyone has heard it. Almost nobody has read it. Taken at walking pace it turns out to be a complete statement of what the Craft believes a man should be — and one of the best pieces of prose in the English ritual.

ON THE TABLE

The Charge after Initiation, read slowly

A MAN, DESCRIBED AS A STRUCTURE

Let prudence direct you, temperance chasten you, fortitude support you, and justice be the guide of all your actions. Look at the verbs.



Not a list of nice qualities. A member at every bearing point.

Diagram drawn for The Vulcan Papers.

HOW THE PAPER RUNS

0:00	Opening
2:00	Part One: the shape of it
5:00	Part Two: the three great duties
9:00	Part Three: the cardinal virtues
12:00	Part Four: as a citizen
15:00	Part Five: the last instruction
18:00	Closing

THREE THINGS TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 It runs God, neighbour, self, state — and puts the Craft fifth out of five.
- 2 Prudence directs, temperance chastens, fortitude supports, justice guides all.
- 3 It ends by requiring a daily advancement in masonic knowledge. That is why this series exists.

IF YOU ARE ASKED



THE CHARGE, LINE BY LINE

Is the Charge secret?

No. It has been published for two centuries and appears in the printed rituals.

How old is it?

It reached substantially its present form in the eighteenth century and was settled at the Union. Its ancestry runs back to the Old Charges.

Why does duty to self come third?

Because a man must be in working order to discharge the other two. It is maintenance, not indulgence.

Why the emphasis on obedience to the state?

Partly defensive — masonry grew up under official suspicion across Europe — and partly meant.

What is "daily advancement"?

The closing instruction of the Charge, and the reason lodges deliver papers at all.

SOURCES

- Emulation Ritual (Lewis Masonic) — the Charge after Initiation, as worked in England
- Anderson, The Constitutions of the Free-Masons, 1723 — the Charges from which it descends
- The Old Charges (Regius, c.1390; Cooke, c.1410) — the ancestry of the form
- Colin Dyer, Symbolism in Craft Freemasonry
- Papers Seven and Eleven in this series, for the religious and historical background

The Charge is published, and has been for two centuries. This paper reads it as a piece of writing. It touches nothing that is not in print.

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